

Week 17

Part 1 - Soroosh Sabri

Digitisation Popularisation

Who decides what gets digitised and for what purposes? Most often, it is what is already deemed to be popular or profitable. In order for archives to be digitised, it requires funding, often from for-profit companies that might not necessarily share an interest in preserving history that would not gather any clicks. On the other hand, archives that are digitised by volunteers could also run into a similar problem, as what gets prioritised often depends on what the public finds most useful or interesting, such as genealogical research. If we as historians over rely on these digital archives, it could lead to only certain aspects of these archives being preserved, which is something we as historians could greatly suffer from.

Questioning Systems Design

It is important that we as historians need to learn how to properly use digital archives. (should be a class for that) The way digital archives are structured through categories, tags, and search functions directly affects how sources are found and understood. Digital archives are not neutral, as they are built in specific ways that can prioritise certain results or guide us towards particular interpretations. If we do not understand how these systems work, we can risk missing important sources or relying too heavily on what the system makes easiest to find.

This means that digital archival literacy becomes necessary as a skill for historians, we can't approach digital archives the same way one could an analogue ones to digital archives, are mediated through the interface, meaning that knowing how to use search functions, understand categories, and question metadata is an important skill for us. Without these skills, historians can overlook relevant sources and base their research on a limited or biased selection of sources. Therefore, learning how digital archives function is not just a technical skill, but an important part of doing reliable historical research.¹

Part 2 - Malte Volquartzen

I have selected David Boder's interview of Ephraim Gutman on September 12, 1946 in Hénouville, France as the subject of my analysis. Compared to some of the other interviews in the archive, there is quite a lot of historical detail provided in the description panel of this interview. In terms of metadata, the archive provides the interview date (1946-09-12), the languages spoken (German primary and Yiddish secondary), the nationality (Ukrainian) and gender (male) of the interviewee, the transcriber (Dagmar Platt) and editor (Eben English) of the tape, format (wire recording) and geographical location for the events discussed (Kaunas/Kovno in Lithuania). The fact that this data is registered separately and not only something

¹ Helle Strandgaard Jensen (2020): Digital Archival Literacy for (all) Historians, Media History, DOI: 10.1080/13688804.2020.177904 <https://doi.org/10.1080/13688804.2020.177904>

that can be found within the tape audio itself or transcription definitely seems like good archival practice. This makes it easier to contextualize the interview and assess its reliability. Also, the fact that this data is registered separately makes it easier to quickly navigate and filter the archive.

As previously stated, the archive provides quite a bit of commentary in the description panel. The explanation for this might be that Ephraim Gutman's personal experience of the holocaust did not include being sent to a concentration camp. He lived for the entire German occupation in the jewish ghetto of Kaunas in Lithuania. Given that this sort of fate is not as widely known as life and death in concentration camps, it seems fitting that the archive provides some historical context for how the holocaust was carried out in the Kaunas ghetto specifically.

II

After listening to the recording itself and reading along with the interview transcription, there are a few things that stood out to me as relevant observations that one might not have access to if solely reading the transcript. There is a certain matter-of-factness in the intonation of Ephraim Gutman. He does not change his tone very much and speaks quite clearly and loudly. He also sometimes speaks quite quickly. Now, this analysis is of course entirely subjective, but I think this might be Gutman's way of keeping the horrible events at an arm's length. This might also explain why he suddenly stopped the interview towards the end when beginning to speak about the final "action" as he calls it against the inhabitants of the Kaunas ghetto. Listening to the recording therefore gives more of an idea of how troubled Ephraim Gutman is than you would gather from only reading the transcript.

In terms of using interviews as a historical source, there are several implications. The Boder interviews seem particularly valuable, since they are some of the earliest interviews with the sound recorded instead of the interviewer merely taking notes. Given how early the testimonies were recorded, it means we avoid the "iconic Holocaust tropes"² muddling the memories of Holocaust survivor testimonies as Presner discusses. And as mentioned above, Gutman's recollection of the events might be (quite naturally) affected by a need to protect himself from the worst of the memories. This is a general thing also touched on by Presner³. Personal testimonies are not always the best for establishing "colder" facts. But as always it's a question of what you are researching, and in the case of the Holocaust there is probably nothing like it for examining the emotional experiences of those persecuted.

Part 3 - Marius Hedegaard Henningsen

² Todd Presner, *Ethics of the Algorithm: Digital Humanities and Holocaust Memory* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2024), 8

³ Presner, *Ethics of the Algorithm*, 8

Compare and contrast the use of digitized historical sources in web-based databases with reborn digital sources in the archived Web. Should these sources be treated differently when conducting historical research? To complete this task, draw on your knowledge of at least two database collections discussed in class and/or your readings. In your response, please support your position using relevant literature from our course, such as Kelley (2019), Johnson (2018), Brügger (2019), and the articles mentioned in part one of this assignment. (500 words)

Digitized historical sources in web-based databases, are derived from structured physical historical documents that, originally were not digital.

A good example of such a database that we've also discussed in class would be the *Transatlantic Slave Trade Database* (slavevoyages.org), that consists of structured records derived from documents like ship manifests, port records, and censuses.

These documents have been cleaned, standardized, and made searchable, making it easier for researchers to estimate how many Africans arrived directly in North America via transatlantic voyages. In that sense such a database allows more precise quantitative investigations of trade routes, slave mortality and regional connections between Africa and the Americas. The historian Sean M. Kelley notes that such databases have "(...)transformed an entire historical field(...)" challenging earlier estimates such as Philip Curtin's estimates on the atlantic slave trade from 1969.⁴

Reborn digital sources in the archived Web, by contrast, are digitally-born sources that have been collected and preserved through web archiving processes like crawling. We call them *reborn* because the sites from which they originate are inactive in the present. An example of a database of reborn digital sources would be *The Wayback Machine*, operated by the *Internet Archive* (web.archive.org)

Unlike digitized historical sources, which usually have an original document you can check against, archived web material has no fixed original. The reborn sources are archived through deliberate choices about how to collect and save the material - for instance there's a difference between using web crawlers, which the Wayback Machine uses and taking simple screenshots - and there are also decisions about what to include: how much data can we store and which time periods to archive. This can leave significant gaps in archival databases that result in *archival silence*.

The two types of sources share similarities - both raise questions of bias, credibility and authenticity. There are also key differences. When digitized database sources are converted into queryable formats, allowing easier statistical analysis, we risk oversimplification. According to Kelley the works of Marcus Rediker and Stephanie Smallwood on the atlantic slave trade suggest, however, that when backing

⁴Sean M. Kelley, "DB or Not DB: Writing the History of the Slave Trade to North America in the Era of the Database," *History Compass* 17, no. 5 (2019). 1

quantitative research with qualitative sources we keep the human experience at the center of the narrative.⁵

Archived Web sources, by comparison, retain more of their original digital form but are still inherently altered by the archiving process itself; what is preserved is not a “1:1 copy” as Niels Brügger suggests, but a transformed version influenced by technical aspects.⁶

To conclude: these sources *should be treated differently* in historical research. Digitized databases require source criticism focused on data construction, gaps in records, and the limits of quantitative research. Archived Web demands awareness of its reborn status: researchers must account for archiving choices, missing elements, and the fact that there isn’t a fixed original version.

Different types of digital sources work in different ways. If you treat them all the same, you risk misunderstanding how reliable they are or what they really show. We must adjust our approach depending on the type of digital source we’re using if we want to study web history properly.

Bibliography

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⁵ Kelley, “DB or Not DB,” 3.

⁶ Niels Brügger, “DIGITAL HISTORIE OG ARKIVERET WEB SOM HISTORISK KILDE”, *Temp - Tidsskrift for Historie* 7, no. 14 (2017), 13